

MS Mail

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FROM Vershbow, Alexander R.
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SUBJECT Options Paper for breakfast [~~SECRET~~]
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CARBON_COPY NO CC's on THIS MESSAGE
TEXT_BODY
Since we've added some new material, we'd like TL to review one more time
before we send to the Principals.
[[GORAZDE.DOC : 4145 in GORAZDE.DOC]]
ATTACHMENT
FILE DATE 17 July 95 16:18
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Options Paper: Position on French Request For Assistance in Defense of Gorazde

Background: The French and British remain far apart following Sunday's meeting of C

HODS in London on their

approach to the issue of reinforcing Gorazde against potential Bosnian Serb attack:

The French have portrayed the

survival of Gorazde as a litmus test of UNPROFOR's future viability; they are prepar

ed to support our proposals

for robust use of air power to protect Gorazde, but have tied this to their proposal to reinforce the peacekeepers

on the ground as a deterrent to Serb aggression; moreover, they insist that only a v

isible commitment of additional

U.S. support in Gorazde, i.e. helicopter airlift, will satisfy Chirac and head off a French decision to withdraw. The

UK argues against anything that would change the nature of the existing UNPROFOR mis

sion, is skeptical about

robust use of air power, and has indicated it does not see the survival of Gorazde as essential to the continuation of UNPROFOR. The British have indicated, however, that they may be willing to consider the option of a "private" warning to the Bosnian Serbs that if they attack Gorazde, NATO will retaliate with a massive air campaign (similar to the UK/U.S./French warning delivered in early June with respect to the hostages).

Our own military analysis (and that of Bosnian Foreign Minister Sacirbey) is that a truly robust air campaign would be far more critical to the defense of Gorazde than the addition of French troops; but it may be difficult to persuade the French to delink this from the deployment of additional ground forces. The challenge is to find a means of satisfying the French concerns over Gorazde that will not be blocked by the UK, while at the same time bolstering UNPROFOR for the more critical task of protecting Sarajevo and central Bosnia and avoiding making the fall of Gorazde the trigger for UNPROFOR withdrawal.

Options: There are two basic options for a U.S. response to the French in preparation for the Foreign and Defense Ministers' meeting scheduled for London on Friday, July 21.

Option 1 "Yes, but..." Tell the French that we are prepared to support their request, but that we view the reinforcement of UNPROFOR in Gorazde as mainly symbolic (as they have implied). The numbers and mission therefore could be scaled back, with emphasis on enhancing the ability to coordinate NATO air support for the enforcement of the exclusion zone and for the Bosnian Government's defense of the enclave. We would make clear that there can be no compromise on insisting that preemptive SEAD and a robust air campaign, without the existing dual key, are the preconditions for U.S. support in

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 lifting the troops: we do not
 intend to take part in flying troops into harm's way if there is no additional realistic capability to defend their
 positions once they are in place. We would also stress that we are not committing
 t
 o participation in any
 resupply effort. And we would state that, while we are in favor of making a
 determini
 ned effort to deter a
 Serb offensive against Gorazde, we would still favor maintaining UNPROFOR in
 Sarajevo
 o and Central Bosnia
 in the event Gorazde falls.

ù Option 2 "No, because..." Tell the French that, absent their ability to present
 a realistic mission for the forces
 they are proposing to send to Gorazde, the troops could be more effectively
 employed
 around Sarajevo, and
 that therefore we could not justify providing helicopters to move them. However,
 ag
 ree with the French that
 a major change in UNPROFOR credibility must be signaled at Gorazde, and
 encourage th
 em to join us in
 persuading the British to support a robust air campaign, supported by preemptive
 SEA
 D, to enforce the
 exclusion zone and assist the Bosnian forces in protecting the Gorazde Safe Area.

Analysis: Either option may be rejected by the British and other troop-
 contributing
 Allies, probably resulting in a
 French decision to pull out of UNPROFOR. Option 1 would reduce French
 ability to p
 ut the blame on us in that
 event. If accepted and our questions are satisfactorily answered, Option 1 would
 re
 quire us to make good on the
 offer to provide helicopter air lift. This would prompt Congressional and public
 op
 position to crossing the "red
 line" toward ground involvement -- opposition that could become unmanageable
 if one
 of our helicopters were
 shot down. Moreover, it could commit us to follow-on actions to save Gorazde if
 the
 Serbs attacked and
 threatened to overrun the enclave.

The robust air campaign envisaged by both options would increase the risk of UN personnel being taken hostage, but without this, neither Gorazde nor Sarajevo may prove viable in the long term. The British willingness to issue a "private" warning (that we would, of course, leak) of a massive air response to an attack on Gorazde could be incorporated into either option. It may not, however, go far enough to satisfy the French interest in visible action on the ground, but it may be the means to unlocking the UN key on SEAD and robust air strikes. If we support this approach, the authority for single-key SEAD and air strikes must be granted in advance, triggered by a Bosnian Serb attack on Gorazde. If also linked to a robust campaign to open land routes to Sarajevo, this might be sufficient to bring the French along, but probably not without direct lobbying by the President with Chirac.

Withdrawal/Redaction Sheet

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001. cable	re. Secretary's Conversation with French FM De Charette (3 pages)	07/21/1995	P1/b(1) KSM

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NSC Cables
Jan 1995-Dec 1996 ([Charette])
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[07/21/1995]

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